



So near, yet so far: Thousands of adoring supporters had paid up to Rs. 12,000 to catch a glimpse of football star Lionel Messi at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata. DEBASISH BHADURI

their events as the best in the world. Try arguing with a Brit by comparing the Spanish La Liga with the English Premier League or questioning Lord's as the home of cricket. See what happens. And here we are, trying to pull down Indians who have taken India to the top, just for a few headlines and a few hundred views or followers.

This is not to suggest that Indian cricket is beyond criticism. If anything, every Indian cricket lover should have the right to express honest views so that Indian cricket can progress and prosper. But writing speculative and critical pieces purely for eyeballs damages Indian cricket, from whose ecosystem we all make a rupee or two.

Even the recent episode at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata, where the Argentinian footballer, Lionel Messi, made a far shorter appearance than promised, was blamed on everyone except the person who failed to honour his commitment. What his agreement

was is not public knowledge, but if he was meant to be at the stadium for an hour, then by leaving well before that time and disappointing fans who had paid good money, the real culprit was he and his entourage. Yes, he was surrounded by politicians and so-called VIPs, but there was no security threat to him or his entourage. Was he supposed to simply walk around the stadium, or do something tangible like take a penalty kick? If it were the latter, those around him would automatically have had to move, and the crowd would have seen their hero do what they had come to watch.

The other appearances went smoothly because commitments were met. So before blaming fellow Indians in Kolkata, it might be worth checking whether commitments on both sides were honoured.

Otherwise, it will be exactly what the Chief of the Intelligence Bureau says in the movie, that "we Indians are India's worst enemies".

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